

Notes 5 - Risk Assessment Process

(Source: <https://www.hse.gov.uk/simple-health-safety/risk/index.htm>)

Risks are future uncertain events, with a probability of occurrence and a potential for loss.

Assessing risk is just one part of the overall process used to control risks in a workplace.

1. Overview

To protect employees, and others, from harm, the minimum an employer must do is:

- identify what could cause injury or illness in a business (hazards)
- decide how likely it is that someone could be harmed and how seriously (the risk)
- take action to eliminate the hazard, or if this isn't possible, control the risk

2. Steps needed to manage risk

Risk management is a step-by-step process for controlling health and safety risks caused by hazards in the workplace.

i.) Identify hazards

Look around the workplace and think about what may cause harm (these are called hazards). Think about:

- how people work and how equipment are used
- what safe or unsafe work practices exist
- the general state of your premises

Look back at the accident and ill health records as these can help you identify less obvious hazards. Take account of non-routine operations, such as maintenance, cleaning or changes in production cycles.

Think about hazards to health, such as manual handling and causes of work-related stress.

For each hazard, think about how employees, contractors, visitors or members of the public might be harmed.

Vulnerable workers

Some workers have particular requirements, for example young workers, migrant workers, new or expectant mothers and people with disabilities.

Talk to workers

Involve employees as they will usually have good ideas.

ii.) Assess the risks

Once hazards have been identified, decide how likely it is that someone could be harmed and how serious it could be. This is assessing the level of risk.

Decide:

- who might be harmed and how
- what we are already doing to control the risks
- what further action we need to take to control the risks
- who needs to carry out the action
- when the action is needed by

iii.) Control the risks

Look at what we are already doing, and the controls you already have in place.

Ask yourself:

- Can I get rid of the hazard altogether?
- If not, how can I control the risks so that harm is unlikely?

If you need further controls,

Consider:

- redesigning the job
- replacing the materials, machinery or process
- organizing your work to reduce exposure to the materials, machinery or process
- identifying and implementing practical measures needed to work safely
- providing personal protective equipment and making sure workers wear it

What reasonably practicable means

Put the controls you have identified in place. You're not expected to eliminate all risks but you need to do everything 'reasonably practicable' to protect people from harm. This means balancing the level of risk against the measures needed to control the real risk in terms of money, time or trouble.

iv.) Record your findings

If you employ 5 or more people, you must record your significant findings, including.

- the hazards (things that may cause harm)
- who might be harmed and how
- what you are doing to control the risks

v) Review the controls

You must review the controls you have put in place to make sure they are working. You should also review them if:

- they may no longer be effective
- there are changes in the workplace that could lead to new risks such as changes to:

- staff,
- a process,
- the substances or equipment used

Also consider a review if your workers have spotted any problems or there have been any accidents or near misses.

Update your risk assessment record with any changes you make.

3. Risk assessment template and examples

Template

You can use a risk assessment template to help you keep a simple record of:

- who might be harmed and how
- what you're already doing to control the risks
- what further action you need to take to control the risks
- who needs to carry out the action
- when the action is needed by

Risk assessment template

Company name:

Assessment carried out by:

Date of next review:

Date assessment was carried out:

What are the hazards?	Who might be harmed and how?	What are you already doing to control the risks?	What further action do you need to take to control the risks?	Who needs to carry out the action?	When is the action needed by?	Done

Example risk assessments

These typical examples show how other businesses have managed risks. You can use them as a guide to think about:

- some of the hazards in your business
- the steps you need to take to manage the risks

Do not just copy an example and put your company name to it as that would not satisfy the law and would not protect your employees. You must think about the specific hazards and controls your business needs.

- Office-based business ([office.pdf](#))
- Local shop/newsagent ([newsagent.pdf](#))
- Food preparation and service ([foodprep.pdf](#))
- Motor vehicle repair shop ([mvr.pdf](#))
- Factory maintenance work ([factory.pdf](#))
- Warehouse ([warehouse.pdf](#))

4. Common workplace risks

To help you find specific guidance on the risks in your workplace, we have grouped together the most common causes of serious injury at work, such as slips and trips or working at height.

Some health conditions can be caused or made worse by work and working environments. These include lung disease, stress and musculoskeletal disorders such as back pain.

Most common risks in the workplace:

Asbestos, Confined spaces, **Display screen equipment**, Electrical safety, Equipment and machinery, Fire safety, Gas safety, Harmful substances, Manual handling, Noise, Personal protective equipment, Pressure equipment, Radiations, Slips and trips, Vibration, Working at height, Workplace transport, **Work-related stress**.